

Annual Review of Sociology

Diversifying Gender Categories and the Sex/Gender System

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Annu. Rev. Sociol. 2024. 50:385–405

First published as a Review in Advance on
April 29, 2024

The *Annual Review of Sociology* is online at
soc.annualreviews.org

<https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-soc-030222-035327>

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Keywords

sex/gender system, transgender, nonbinary, survey measurement, gender identity, gender inequality

Abstract

The growing visibility of transgender and nonbinary people raises important sociological questions about how the structure of sex and gender is shifting and underscores necessary changes to research practice. We review what is known about emerging gender identities and their implications for sociological understandings of the relationship between sex and gender and the maintenance of the sex/gender system of inequality. Transgender and nonbinary identities are increasingly common among younger cohorts and improved survey measurements of sex and gender are expanding information about these changes. In the United States, an additional gender category seems to be solidifying in public usage even as the higher status of masculinity over femininity persists. The continuing power of the normative binary contributes to both violent backlash and characteristic patterns of discrimination against gender diverse people; yet, underlying support for nondiscrimination in the workplace is stronger than commonly recognized. New, more consistent efforts to account for gender diversity in social science research are needed to fully understand these changes.

INTRODUCTION

The structure of sex and gender has been changing in many ways in recent decades, in the United States as well as in other countries, and the most striking aspect of these changes is the increasing visibility of transgender and nonbinary gender identities (Barbee & Schrock 2019, Lagos 2022). People we would currently call transgender or nonbinary (see definitions) have existed both historically and across a range of cultures (Herdt 1993, Stryker 2017). Thus, what is changing is not the existence of people whose gender differs from their assigned sex, or who challenge gender as binary, but the growing percentage of people who actively claim these identities and their public visibility. Expanding individual-level identity claims have accompanied changes in the measurement of sex and gender in surveys, coproducing the diversification of gender categories. Bureaucratic recognition of gender diversity is increasing as well, such as the recently added X option to US passports and the ability to choose a third category on a growing array of routine forms. The seeming seismic shift to personal identity as the preeminent basis for categorization has not been uniformly embraced, however, and attempts to recover the status quo have been highly visible, vitriolic and even violent (Kline et al. 2023, Westbrook 2023, Westbrook & Schilt 2014).

These changes in the visibility of transgender and nonbinary gender identities are the phenomena around which our review is centered. In addition to reviewing the changing nature of identity claims and institutional efforts to record them, we consider the implications of diversifying gender categories for the maintenance of the sex/gender system and gender status inequality. We focus on developments in the United States over the past 10–15 years, although we situate them in their broader historical and global contexts. As changes are ongoing and the terminology of gender categories is in flux, our summaries necessarily reflect a snapshot in time. Our review also complements other recent reviews on expanding sexual and gender minority identities and the development of transgender studies in sociology (Risman et al. 2022, Russell et al. 2023, Schilt & Lagos 2017).

To address the issues raised by diversifying gender categories, we draw on an orienting perspective to sex/gender as a multilevel system or structure of inequality in the United States that involves selves and identities at the individual level; interpersonal relations at the interactional level; and cultural beliefs, legal rights and economic and institutional arrangements at the structural/cultural level (Ridgeway & Correll 2004, Risman 2004). Gender is one of society's primary frames for making sense of the self and others and for organizing social behavior (Martin & Slepian 2021, Ridgeway 2011). Because of this, people feel pressured to hold each other accountable to cultural norms of gender performance that make everyone predictable to others (West & Zimmerman 1987), and individuals face the necessity of making their sex/gender legible to others in virtually all situations (Lucal 1999). Gender as an intersecting system of inequality is built in relation to the social assignment of bodies to a sex category.

Gender inequality is driven by the social status associated with one sex/gender category compared with another (Ridgeway 2011). As a result, the sex/gender system depends on people having mutually intelligible categories. Among the challenges faced by people forging new ways of relating to sex and gender is to find or forge new categories of identity that are rooted in and intelligible to a community of others. As our account shows, sex/gender categories are the fulcrum around which cultural understandings of gender difference and inequality turn.

New ways of conceptualizing gender at times seem to decouple individual identity from the constraints of anatomy and physiology. Yet, as with changing conceptions of race, efforts to root these concepts in biology and genetics can prove surprisingly durable (see Brubaker 2015). Therefore, we start by reviewing changing understandings of the relationship between sex and gender and their implications for changes in measurement and how new categories are being

Sex: a categorization of bodies based on normative biological standards such as chromosomes, hormones, genitals, or other anatomical traits

Gender: social relations based on expectations of behavior inferred from sex categories, currently a status hierarchy favoring men over women

Transgender: when a person's gender identity differs from their sex assigned at birth

Nonbinary: an umbrella term for gender identities other than woman and man, which can represent a combination of both, neither or fluidity in between

institutionalized. This leads to a consideration of what new measures reveal about the changing landscape of gender categories and the social processes through which people forge shared meanings for these newly visible identities.

Next, we examine how gender diversity is received within mainstream, cisgender contexts. Recent studies reveal the underpinnings of transgender and nonbinary prejudice and the distinctive pattern of discrimination and stigmatization against gender diverse people that results. Considering where such change and resistance in the sex/gender system will lead, we review evidence both for the public emergence of a third category of gender and for the maintenance of the gender status hierarchy that privileges masculinity over femininity. We conclude by highlighting methodological improvements and the types of studies necessary to track these ongoing changes in the sex/gender system.

Cisgender:

when a person's gender identity is the same as their sex assigned at birth

THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN SEX AND GENDER

Debates about the nature of sex and gender boil down to three interrelated questions: (a) how to understand the direction of causality between biological and social differences, (b) whether either sex or gender should be seen as fixed, and (c) whether human diversity in this respect is best described as more of a continuum or as falling into two mutually exclusive categories. Although many sociologists have come to adopt antiessentialist and nonbinary perspectives on these questions, residues of older approaches remain entrenched in many areas of research, which contributes to the general public's ability to cite science as supporting their opposing views about the nature of sex and gender (Parker et al. 2022, Sudai et al. 2022).

Which Came First?

Feminist social scientists began adopting the term “gender” in the 1970s to mark an analytical distinction between the biological aspects of sex and the learned or social aspects of what had previously been called sex roles (Haig 2004). Gender came to be seen as a cultural construction and a way of organizing society that rests on a foundation of perceived biological difference. In this framework, sex is causally prior to gender: the biological categories of females and males were largely taken for granted, but the social interpretation of these differences now required explanation. This represented a paradigm shift in sociology that allowed for questioning the biological essentialism of existing research on so-called “sex differences” while subjecting everyday practices of gender relations to empirical analysis (e.g., Ferree et al. 1999, p. xviii). The epitome of this approach is West & Zimmerman's (1987) theory of “doing gender,” where everyone has a socially assigned script for their gender performance that is determined by their sex category; people may deviate from their assigned scripts but will also be held accountable by others for doing so.

This new consensus view of gender faced some criticism, even as it began to emerge. Some scholars wondered why biological difference should be given primacy when, as Connell (1985, p. 268) put it, “we always see the ‘natural’ through social spectacles.” From this perspective, social commitments to gender and gender inequality shape how we interpret human biological variation (Kessler & McKenna 1978). Thus, sex becomes something people manipulate to better match their beliefs about gender. Recent scholarship echoes this view by exposing the binary and essentialist assumptions built into everything from theories of brain development (Jordan-Young 2011) and sex determination (Fujimura 2006) to medical research on testosterone (Jordan-Young & Karkazis 2019) and treatment protocols for children with intersex variations (Davis 2015, Eder 2022).

The synthesis of these two perspectives sees sex and gender as inextricably intertwined, each relying on the other for its seeming legitimacy as a primary frame for understanding social life, while producing feedback loops between biological and social processes. From Rubin's initial

THE SEX/GENDER/SEXUALITY SYSTEM

Although it is useful to make analytical distinctions between sex and gender, the concepts are difficult to separate in practice. The same is true for separating sex or gender and sexuality. Traditional understandings of sexual orientation are founded on beliefs about binary sexes, highlighting distinctions between relationships that are heterosexual (different sexes), homosexual (same sexes), and bisexual (both sexes). However, this categorization begins to break down, or is forced to expand, when there are more than two sexes and when a person's gender is different from their sex assigned at birth. Thus, changes in our understanding of sex and gender lead to changes in our understanding of sexuality, and vice versa (Westbrook 2022).

This can be seen in the recent expansion of gender and sexual identities (Russell et al. 2023). Terms indicating an openness to all sexes/genders, such as pansexual and queer, are becoming more common among younger cohorts alongside growth in transgender and nonbinary gender identities (Goldberg et al. 2020, Hammack et al. 2022). Bisexual identification also has grown rapidly over at least the past decade, especially among young women (Jones 2022; see also Mishel et al. 2020). What remains unclear at present is whether more inclusive sexual identities are serving as placeholders while people negotiate their gender identities and sexual desires in young adulthood (see Bridges & Moore 2018) or whether they are a harbinger of more permanent shifts in the US sex/gender/sexuality system.

formulation of the “sex/gender system” (Rubin 1975, p. 159) to contemporary discussions of “gender/sex” in psychology (e.g., Morgenroth & Ryan 2021), scholars continue to recognize the analytical value of distinguishing between the two concepts—and between the various dimensions of each concept (e.g., NASEM 2022)—even as they highlight the challenge of ever fully separating them in practice (Springer et al. 2012; see also the sidebar titled The Sex/Gender/Sexuality System).

Fixed or Fluid?

Coming to see gender as learned or social is not necessarily the same as seeing it as a fluid characteristic, and the same goes for sex. That is, people can perceive either concept to be primarily biological or primarily social while also believing it to be static or fixed over the life course of a particular individual. The full range of views exist, from both sex and gender being fixed (because both are seen as natural and interchangeable) to both sex and gender being fluid (because both are seen as contextually dependent and under some individual control).

Seeing gender as fluid is often treated as a corollary of seeing it as socially constructed because both the categories and how they are translated into social organization have changed over time and differ across societies. The “doing gender” perspective also highlights repeated individual performances that can change across contexts (West & Zimmerman 1987). Yet gender identity and its potential fluidity did not become a focus of research attention until the turn of the twenty-first century, following the emergence of transgender as a category of experience and identity (Valentine 2007). More than 20 years later, gender fluidity beyond a unidirectional and one-time transition continues to be challenged by both normative cisgender and some transgender perspectives (Sumerau et al. 2020), limiting its visibility in both everyday life and academic research.

The claim that sex should not be treated as static is based in both the natural variation that can occur over an individual's life course and the malleability of many sex characteristics in the face of human intervention (Ainsworth 2015). Hormone levels change at different times of the day, on different days of the month, and over the years from puberty to menopause and beyond. Hormone supplements and cosmetic surgery to either maintain or alter sex characteristics are not

Gender identity: a person's sense of self in relation to the gender system of their particular time and place

uncommon (Rosenthal 2023). Even chromosomes must be replicated in each new cell, with the possibility for karyotype variations across cells and organ systems. Thus, in many cases, the only thing about a person's sex that is truly fixed is the category that they were assigned at birth.

Perhaps the most unexpected conceptual combination, from a sociological perspective, is the belief that gender, and in particular gender identity, is fixed while sex is malleable. This hypothesis emerged in the 1950s from the work of John Money and colleagues, who were studying children with intersex conditions or differences of sexual development. Money is credited with coining the term "gender role" to describe how the children were raised by their parents—as boys or girls—in ways that did not necessarily match their anatomy or other biological characteristics (Haig 2004). However, Money used the metaphor of imprinting and saw one's gender role as effectively fixed by age two. Thus, the task for medicine was to bring ambiguously sexed bodies in line with this static gender (Eder 2022). The legacy of this approach to gender continues today in theories that speculate one's gender identity is determined by exposure to hormone levels in utero, or through other biological or genetic mechanisms that yield a sense of self that is innate and immutable (Gonsalves 2020). Often described colloquially as a narrative of being "born this way" (see Schilt 2015), such perspectives affirm the primacy of self-identification and allow for one's gender to differ from one's sex chromosomes or anatomy but treat gender as a core individual attribute that is effectively fixed.

Beyond the Binary

Among the many lessons to be learned from the medical history of transgender and intersex people is the taken-for-granted nature of the sex/gender binary. Both transgender and intersex people were seen as problems to be solved by removing ambiguity and choosing from "two and only two" categories (Davis et al. 2016; Kessler & McKenna 1978, p. 113). Intersex children were seen as best served by reshaping their bodies into whichever category their parents planned to raise them, with healthy outcomes being defined as both gender conformity and heterosexuality as adults (Davis et al. 2016, Eder 2022). Transgender adults were required to prove their worthiness for surgery and hormone treatment through conformity to traditional gender roles and heterosexuality as well (Shuster 2021). As Gagné and colleagues (1997, p. 484) put it, only a few "gender radicals" tried to challenge convention and refuse to pick a side.

Yet, from a scientific perspective, the idea that there are only two sexes and, thus, only two genders has become harder and harder to maintain. For example, the distributions of human sex characteristics may be bimodal, but they are not strictly binary, and the combination of variation across chromosomes, hormone levels, and both primary and secondary sex characteristics is more complex still (Ainsworth 2015, Fujimura 2006). As Fausto-Sterling (1993) famously declared, this makes for at least five sexes, not just two. New social histories have traced changing beliefs about nonbinary bodies over time (DeVun 2021). Even contemporary views of biological variation among animals argue for more complexity (Todd et al. 2016).

Emerging alongside these challenges to academic and medical practice are newly explicit nonbinary identities (Barbee & Schrock 2019, Darwin 2020). People have begun to articulate their self-understandings as not simply as female/woman or male/man but as potentially fluid combinations of both or neither, as signified by terms such as genderqueer, genderfluid, gender-nonconforming, and agender. Like Morgenroth & Ryan (2021), we maintain that tracing the effects of all this "gender trouble" (Butler 1990) is a key task for future research.

THE CHANGING LANDSCAPE OF CATEGORIES

Although there are long-standing calls for better conceptualization and measurement of sex and gender, most data collection continues to conflate sex and gender and treats both characteristics as

static and binary. This gap between social science theory and methods is particularly common in quantitative research (Westbrook & Saperstein 2015) and has only recently begun to narrow, along with broader institutional changes in the recognition of gender diversity in the United States. These changes to official enumeration and identity registration—however partial and tentative at present—not only signify potential shifts in the sex/gender system but also raise the stakes for social science research to keep apace.

Over the past decade, several large-scale national surveys have begun including measurement approaches that acknowledge nonbinary categories, but such changes still have not spread to flagship federal data collection, such as the Current Population Survey (which supplies data for the official unemployment rate), the annual American Community Survey (which supplies representative population estimates for a range of purposes) or the decennial census (NASEM 2022). Administrative data collection has also shifted inconsistently across states and local jurisdictions, creating a patchwork of practices that result in transgender and nonbinary people being registered differently in different domains (Currah 2022). Inconsistent classifications across identity documents can compromise everyday experiences that cisgender people take for granted, from healthcare delivery to travel safety to voting eligibility (Fielding 2020, Grasso et al. 2021, Quinan & Bresser 2020), which both underscores the importance of being counted and consistently recorded and demonstrates how the categorization system itself is implicated in the production of inequality.

Currently, in the United States, 22 states and the District of Columbia have added nonbinary options to driver's licenses (Mov. Adv. Proj. 2024), and the federal government has begun offering nonbinary X markers on passports (Hernandez 2021). Sixteen states also allow residents to amend their birth certificates to a nonbinary classification, though female and male remain the only federally recognized options for sex at birth. Electronic health records increasingly recognize transgender and nonbinary patients (Grasso et al. 2021), and pilot programs are exploring the collection of gender identity for death certificates, including nonbinary categories, as well (Blosnich et al. 2022). Several states have registered dissent by making it more difficult to change sex or gender classifications in administrative data, but the overall trend over the past decade has been away from fixed, binary categorization and toward recognizing fluidity, nonbinary people, and self-identification.

Similar initiatives have expanded options for and loosened restrictions to legal gender recognition in at least a dozen countries (CDADI 2022, Hernandez 2021, NASEM 2022). Transgender and nonbinary people are increasingly being counted in national censuses as well. In 2011, Nepal was the first country to include a third sex or gender category in its census; India and Pakistan soon followed, though *hijra* populations in these countries remain highly stigmatized (Hossain 2017). More recently, Canada claimed credit for being the first country to release detailed census data on transgender and nonbinary people, announcing that 0.3% of its population 15 and older identified as transgender or nonbinary (Stat. Can. 2022), with higher proportions among younger people and those living in cities. England and Wales, Scotland, and New Zealand also allowed for residents to register transgender and nonbinary identities in their latest censuses (in 2021, 2022, and 2023, respectively), and Australia has promised more inclusive measures for its upcoming 2026 count (Wedesweiler 2023). Internationally, then, the United States is lagging rather than leading in counting transgender and nonbinary people in its national statistics.

There also has been considerable debate about how to count, while balancing both preferences expressed by transgender and nonbinary people and the slow expansion of terminological understanding among cisgender people (Glick et al. 2018, Puckett et al. 2020, Suen et al. 2020). In the United States, efforts to include transgender people began in the mid-2000s with local community studies and public health surveillance initiatives. Since then, studies have employed a range

of approaches from simply tacking on a third category (such as transgender) to existing “Are you male or female. . .?” questions to testing new nonbinary categorical and gradational gender measures (Saperstein & Westbrook 2021). In 2014, the Williams Institute summarized then-existing research and recommended what has come to be known as the two-step method of asking survey respondents separately about their sex assigned at birth and current gender identity (GenIUSS Group 2014, p. 9). This recommendation was recently reiterated by an expert panel organized by the National Academies of Sciences, Engineering and Medicine (NASEM 2022). Although every categorization scheme involves trade-offs between visibility and erasure (Bowker & Star 2000, Labuski & Keo-Meier 2015), the two-step approach has been favored over various one-question alternatives because it yields more inclusive estimates that account for both identity (currently identifying as transgender or nonbinary) and experience (identifying as a binary gender that is different from one’s sex assigned at birth) in counting transgender people. Research to date also points to the importance of being able to disaggregate the experiences of cisgender, transgender, and nonbinary people (e.g., Tordoff et al. 2019).

Unsurprisingly, given variation in question formats and the absence of explicit federal standards for sex and gender data collection, existing surveys offer a range of population estimates. Perhaps the most highly cited estimate, that 0.6% of US adults are transgender, relies on select state-level data from an interviewer-assisted telephone survey and a single question about transgender identity (Flores et al. 2016). More recently, the Pew Research Center conducted a nationally representative online self-completion survey and estimated that 1% of US adults identify as nonbinary, 0.6% identify as a different binary gender than their sex assigned at birth, and 0.5% selected another identity besides woman or man, using the two-step approach (Brown 2022). More than a decade of Gallup data also show that combined identification as lesbian, gay, bisexual, or transgender (LGBT) doubled between 2012 and 2021 (Jones 2022)—from 3.5% to 7%—with the increase driven primarily by increases in bisexual identification and entirely by cohort replacement (i.e., greater LGBT identification among younger cohorts rather than change over time within cohorts).

A more detailed portrait of the US transgender and nonbinary population has been difficult to pin down without consistent measurement and nationally representative samples (Henderson et al. 2019). Generational differences are most obvious, with as many as 5% of adults under 30 identifying as transgender or nonbinary (Brown 2022; see also Lagos 2022). Some data also suggest that transgender identity is more common among people who identify as Hispanic or Latine, American Indian or Alaska Native, or multiracial (Herman et al. 2022). Other studies point to nonbinary gender identities being most common among people who were assigned female at birth (e.g., Hammack et al. 2022, Puckett et al. 2022). Compositional and intersectional differences such as these have important implications for understanding inequality both within and between gender categories, a point to which we return below.

FORGING SHARED MEANINGS FOR NEW GENDER CATEGORIES

Changes in how gender identities are counted at the institutional level and recognized in public discourse reflect a top-down process of defining gender categories. But these top-down processes must also contend with the bottom-up processes by which individuals forge together meanings for new categories of gender identity. Identities, as theory and research shows, are always defined in relation to others and the culture of the surrounding group and society (Stets & Serpe 2016, Stryker 1980). Thus, changes in gender identities necessarily involve interplays among selves, others, and groups with their shared cultural beliefs. Given the continued power of the cisgender binary in most public settings (see below), developing new gender identities requires access to

Sex assigned at birth:

a sex categorization formalized on a birth certificate, generally based on casual inspection of the infant’s external genitalia

information and opportunities for ties outside such settings to create new communities of shared, alternative gender meanings.

Studies of people seeking to forge a gender identity outside the cisgender binary consistently document a process by which people reach out, via social media and in person, to discover like-minded others with whom to define a new understanding of their gendered selves (e.g., Darwin 2020, Gagné et al. 1997, Garrison 2018). For example, Nordmarken (2023) describes the “coming into identity” process as beginning with exposure to expansive gender information, most often by meeting gender diverse others, in person or online, and developing through these encounters a new vocabulary to conceptualize the self. Hammack et al. (2022) also observed a process of gender identity exploration and socially based relabeling among adolescents in gender diverse community settings. However, as both studies emphasize, access to gender expansive information and opportunities to find such diverse and supportive others are frequently segmented by race and not equally available to all, making the process of forging a new identity more difficult for some than others.

Out of the process of developing a shared understanding of their new gender identities, these alternative communities, which can be local and small, develop informal norms about what it means to be transgender or trans, or nonbinary, queer, or another label (Darwin 2020, Garrison 2018). In specifying the nature of the new identity and its basis in self-determination, these norms implicitly situate that identity in opposition/relation to the dominant binary and its assumptions about the relationships among sex, behavioral and bodily presentation, and categorical gender identity (see Gonsalves 2020, Hammack et al. 2022). By defining alternative ways to do gender, accountability regimes emerge to support the community’s new identity understandings and uses of gender labels (Darwin 2020, Nordmarken 2023). On the other side, however, such accountability regimes also enforce their identity understandings in ways that can be exclusionary for gender seekers with different senses of what it means to be transgender or otherwise outside the cisgender binary (Hammack et al. 2022). Several studies, for instance, describe nonbinary people experiencing being not “trans enough” in some transgender communities (Darwin 2020, Garrison 2018, Worthen 2021), echoing institutional norms that also have shaped what it means to be transgender (Johnson 2015). This can create tension between reckoning with accountability in some community spaces, while also conforming to binary cisgender norms in the public sphere to avoid transphobia (see, e.g., Abelson 2019).

Across multiple communities and groups, diverse norms are beginning to emerge. As a consequence, the cultural meanings of the categories of transgender and nonbinary are currently in flux, including among people who identify outside the cisgender binary (Schudson & Morgenroth 2022). For instance, nonbinary people do not uniformly identify as transgender and vice versa (Darwin 2020, Wilson & Meyer 2021). Importantly, while some seek to escape gender labels or categories altogether, Hammack et al. (2022) found that most of the adolescents they studied actively valued new categorical labels as an aid to finding community and making their gender identity legible to others (see also Diamond & Butterworth 2008, Garrison 2022), reinforcing our earlier point that the sex/gender system turns on people having mutually intelligible categories of identity.

THE CONTINUING SALIENCE OF GENDER AND THE POWER OF THE BINARY

Since the categorical assignment of people as women or men powerfully shapes the roles they play and the status they attain in society, one might expect or hope that the destabilization of the binary structure of gender categories and their links to sex might reduce the salience and importance of

gender in people's lives and the structure of society (Risman et al. 2022). For example, expanding the use of the singular "they" as a pronoun for everybody, not just nonbinary people, interrupts the linguistic need to gender categorize others based on appearance or other attributes, potentially reducing stereotyping and inequality, especially in status consequential contexts like the classroom or workplace (Saguy & Williams 2022). However, as Brubaker (2023) observes, when a core category of identity is no longer an automatic ascription, it becomes more open to self-reflection and questioning, which increases its social salience. For the moment, then, the many social and behavioral practices associated with the diversification of gender categories—including self-designated pronouns (Saguy & Williams 2022)—appears, if anything, to have increased the salience of gender in everyday experience.

Part of the continuing salience of gender for everyday social relations comes from the heightened awareness of gender fluidity, but another more powerful part comes from gender's roots as a fundamental aspect of social identity by which people make sense of self and other and organize social relations. Martin & Mason (2022) conducted a series of experiments on what it takes for people to see nonhuman entities (e.g., moving shapes) as human and found that inferring gender in the entity was closely linked to humanizing it. They also found that stripping gender from both nonhuman entities and individuals caused them to be perceived as less fully human. As these disturbing experiments demonstrate, gender remains a primary frame by which we make sense of people and ourselves even as gender is changing. This process need not require binary gender categories. In the context of a prevailing binary norm, however, the deep rootedness of gender as a primary category of person perception fuels the resonant power of that binary in people's behavior and judgments. This is especially the case in public contexts like the workplace that implicitly follow cisgender cultural norms and beliefs about gender, including those that accord men higher status (Cheryan & Markus 2020, Ridgeway 2011, Yavorsky 2016).

At the core of the norms and beliefs by which binary gender organizes behavior in public places are widely held cultural stereotypes of women and men. These stereotypes, which constitute the content of binary categories, are hegemonic in that they are institutionalized in public representations of people and implicitly raced as white (Chavez & Wingfield 2018, Gonsalves 2024, Ridgeway & Kricheli-Katz 2013). Until recently, efforts to reduce the constraining power of the binary over people's lives have focused primarily on altering these cultural stereotypes to imply less difference and inequality (Brubaker 2023). Gender stereotypes in the United States have indeed changed since the 1970s in response to women's increased economic and political roles in society. Although women continue to be seen as more communal than men, they are no longer seen as less intelligent (Eagly et al. 2020). Women are still viewed as less forcefully agentic than men, however, so that they continue to face status bias in the workplace and elsewhere, even if that bias is weaker than in previous decades (Charlesworth & Banaji 2022, Eagly et al. 2020, Quadlin 2018). Furthermore, the use of gender stereotypes remains robust in the culture, as reflected in everyday language use by children and adults (Charlesworth et al. 2021). The overall picture is of modest but not transformational change to binary gender categories.

It is against this framework that transgender and nonbinary people engage with others in public settings. Studies clarify the mechanisms by which the binary gender frame produces discrimination against those outside that frame. Stern & Rule (2018) asked study participants to evaluate photos of transgender people in varying stages of transition from women to men and found that the degree of androgyny in a person's appearance and the time it took participants to gender categorize them predicted negative evaluations of them, especially by participants with conservative ideology. Broussard & Warner (2019, p. 410) found that even transgender people whose gender expression conforms to the binary evoke "distinctiveness threat" by blurring the presumed boundaries between the sexes. Again, threat and disliking reactions were stronger among those

with more conservative and essentialist gender beliefs, a finding common to studies of the predictors of transgender prejudice (Hatch et al. 2022, Parker et al. 2022, Schudson & Morgenroth 2022). Such reactions are not without consequence. Studies suggest that transgender people have worse outcomes than cisgender people across a range of socioeconomic domains (Carpenter et al. 2020, Conron & O'Neill 2022, Shannon 2022).

Taken together, existing research suggests that difficulty categorizing and rendering people intelligible according to the cisgender binary as well as perceived threat to essentialist understandings of sex/gender underlie negative reactions, including violence. Even short of violence, such negative reactions to a deeply felt personal identity like gender are painful to experience (Kolber 2023). These backlash reactions produce a characteristic pattern of discrimination and stigmatization. Nonbinary people typically experience the greatest discrimination in the workplace and elsewhere, although such experiences are common for all people who do not conform to the cisgender binary. Fogarty & Zheng (2018, p. 87) found that even in the San Francisco area, which, in contrast to many places, has transgender friendly policies, nonbinary people in the workplace were more likely than other gender diverse workers to be called by the wrong pronouns and were pressured to “just pick one” binary gender (see also Hennekam & Ladge 2023).

Worthen (2021, p. 346) examined stigmatization of nonbinary/genderqueer people by both cisgender and transgender women and men using nationally representative data. Nonbinary people were distinctively stigmatized as having an impermanent identity that was seen as “just a phase” and for their lack of adherence to either femininity or masculinity. Cisgender men, positioned highest in the binary sex/gender system, were the most likely to stigmatize in this way, but transgender men and transgender women did as well. Interestingly, cisgender women, the low-status members of the binary order, were the least likely to stigmatize nonbinary people. Schudson & Morgenroth (2022, p. 2) similarly report nonbinary people being treated as though their gender identity is “fake,” and that cisgender men express greater prejudice toward nonbinary people than other groups. As this suggests, higher-status groups may be especially likely to push back against changes to the sex/gender system to protect their own advantage in the current gender status hierarchy.

CHANGING CATEGORIES AND INEQUALITY

Where will these swirling currents of change and resistance in the structure of sex and gender lead us? It is always risky to forecast the future but, at minimum, it appears that at least one additional gender category is emerging into common linguistic and socio-cognitive use. In US political discourse, transgender seems to be broadly used as an umbrella term for everyone outside the cisgender binary. More than four in ten Americans report knowing a transgender person—up from three in ten when Pew first asked in 2016—and while about the same number report unease with the pace of gender change, that very unease is an acknowledgment that a gender category beyond the binary is emerging within their experience of public life (Parker et al. 2022).

The best evidence of the emergence of a new category would be cisgender women and men spontaneously using the new category to make sense of other people. A recent experiment shows a nationally representative sample of Americans doing something very close to that (Khanna & Meadow 2023). Respondents were presented with a vignette about a 7-year-old boy or girl with preferences for toys and activities that either conformed or nonconformed to stereotypes for their sex assigned at birth, or, in a third condition, who had nonconforming preferences and stated they identified with the other gender. Respondents were asked to rate the likelihood the child was transgender along with the perceived abnormality of the child's behavior. Children with nonconforming behavior were rated as significantly more likely to be transgender, and the effect was

strongest when the child had an explicit gender-nonconforming identity. The labeling of children as transgender was itself gendered in that boys with feminine behavior were rated significantly more likely to be transgender than girls with masculine behavior. Although the survey prompted respondents to consider the category transgender, they appeared to do so readily, suggesting that the category was entering their routine usage. As Khanna & Meadow (2023, p. 557) noted, negative assessments of gender performance according to the normative binary, which used to be simply a path to gender failure, are now also a path to a new category: transgender.

As the number of people who publicly identify outside the cisgender binary continues to grow, encounters with transgender and nonbinary people throughout society will also become more routine, and it is possible that threat and discrimination reactions will dissipate. Recent evidence suggests that underlying support for the rights of transgender people in the workplace is actually quite high in the US adult population and higher than most people think it is (Aksoy et al. 2024, Doan et al. 2022, Lewis et al. 2022). In a study that corrected for social desirability bias, about three-fourths of respondents in a nationally representative sample said they would be comfortable with a transgender manager at work and agreed that employment discrimination against transgender people should be prohibited (Aksoy et al. 2024). Interestingly, despite their own supportive attitudes, respondents estimated that the views of the general population were substantially less positive on both issues, possibly influenced by recent and highly visible legal attacks on transgender rights. Thus, there is pluralistic ignorance about the true level of support for transgender people in the workplace, a condition that could foretell greater future tolerance. The acceptance of self-determination as a legitimate basis for gender identity also may grow, as it is consistent with the broader intensification of individualism and the value of self-expression in American society (Charles & Bradley 2009, Santos et al. 2017).

The implications of an emergent third category for categorical gender inequality will depend on both the status value that becomes attached to the category and how that category alters the current status implications of the binary categories of (cisgender) women and men. Gender inequality currently turns on the greater status, esteem, and presumed performance capacity associated with men and masculinity and the relative devaluation of women and femininity (England 2010, Ridgeway 2011). Although, in theory, a third category could assume any position in this hierarchy, current evidence points toward either a middle, so-called buffer, status between cisgender women and men or a more abject social position below cisgender women.

A low-status position for the emergent third category might be expected to the extent that challenges to the cisgender binary continue to be perceived as threatening to people's sense of the social order and the perceived predictability of others' actions (see Broussard & Warner 2019, Oswald et al. 2023, Stern & Rule 2018, Worthen 2021). Khanna & Meadow (2023), for instance, found that perceptions that a child's gender-nonconforming behavior was abnormal partially mediated the perceived likelihood that the child was transgender. Current levels of threat-fueled backlash also point to a low-status position for a transgender category, but alternatives are possible.

To the extent that the broad category of transgender people comes to be seen as embodying in varying degrees the traits, behaviors, and presentations of both femininity and masculinity, a middle status position could develop. In particular, if nonbinary identities are adopted by higher-status members of existing gender categories (see, e.g., Alfrey & Twine 2017) and/or if greater state recognition is extended consistently in legal and bureaucratic procedures, a middle status position might become more likely over time. At present, it seems that people assigned female at birth are more likely to adopt a nonbinary identity that combines femininity and masculinity than those assigned male are to similarly exit the higher-status category of men (Darwin 2020, Hammack et al. 2022). In a vignette experiment on workplace perceptions of employees, Dray and

colleagues (2020) found that, among employees assigned male at birth, people identifying as non-binary were seen as less likable than people identifying as either binary transgender or cisgender. Likability affected performance evaluations. However, among employees assigned female at birth, people identifying as nonbinary were liked slightly more than cisgender women, apparently reflecting the status devaluation of women and the feminine. Fears about a “flight from womanhood” also motivate backlash toward transgender people from some bioessentialist feminists (Lagos 2022, p. 105, Hines 2020), highlighting perceived group status threats (Morgenroth & Ryan 2021).

Even as a third category solidifies, however, there are likely to be inequalities within the broad umbrella of transgender identities. Given the growing importance of nonbinary as a distinct identity, it is possible general perceptions will follow suit and further differentiate between transgender and nonbinary identities. If cultural acceptance of self-determination as a basis for gender identity continues to increase, binary-identified and behaviorally conforming transgender people may be more fully accepted as women and men and take on the gender status of those categories. Importantly, who can conform to traditional binary gender presentation, even among those who wish to, is not equally distributed; gender-affirming medical care is expensive, which limits access to people with more resources (e.g., Travers 2018). Research on labor market outcomes for transgender people points to income disparities by not only sex assigned at birth but also transition and disclosure status, among other factors (Shannon 2022). Bullying, discrimination, and violence are also disproportionately targeted toward transgender women and, particularly, transgender women of color (e.g., Greene 2019, Greene & Ervin 2024, Westbrook 2023).

Overall, evidence suggests the changing landscape of gender categories is not eroding the higher status currently associated with masculine traits and behaviors and the relative devaluation of stereotypically feminine traits and behaviors. Several studies suggest that the higher status of masculinity has persisted in the face of the growth in transgender and nonbinary identities. In Khanna & Meadow’s (2023) study, hypothetical boys with (devalued) feminine behaviors were seen as more abnormal and were more likely to be reclassified as transgender than were hypothetical girls with equally gender-nonconforming (but higher-status) masculine behaviors. The treatment of binary-identified transgender people also reflects the greater status afforded to men in society. Schilt (2010) found that transgender men gained a status dividend that allowed them to be incorporated to some extent within the binary gender hierarchy. Yavorsky (2016) suggests that transgender women, in contrast, have more difficult experiences in the workplace since they must navigate both sexism and cisgenderism. The greater status accorded men, however, is racialized (Chavez & Wingfield 2018, Ridgeway & Kricheli-Katz 2013). Transgender men of color, for instance, can find themselves newly viewed by others as threatening, which subjects them to more aggressive police encounters (de Vries 2012). Thus, the constellation of status hierarchies that supports contemporary inequality may not be disrupted by the emergence of additional, publicly recognized gender categories.

Although current evidence points to the persistence of a gender status hierarchy that privileges masculinity, that does not mean that the categories of (cisgender) women and men will remain unchanged by the emergence of a third category. It is possible binary genders will become even more traditional or stereotypical in the face of exit to nonbinary identities (Brubaker 2023; see also Gonsalves 2024). This compositional change also may be counteracted to some extent for women, given that the long-term trend in gender stereotypes is for women to take on more masculine traits without equivalent change in the stereotypes of men (e.g., Eagly et al. 2020). Nevertheless, central to the meaning of a transgender category is that gender identities can and, perhaps, should be self-determined rather than societally determined. This idea reflects on cisgender identities as well, suggesting that they, too, should be a positive choice, not just an assigned fate.

FACILITATING FUTURE RESEARCH

Although predictions about future gender inequality that account for transgender and nonbinary people remain uncertain, it is clear sociologists—and researchers across disciplines—need to be attentive to these changes in the sex/gender system. Doing so will require both adding new tools to our methodological toolkits and sharpening existing ones. Many of the necessary changes to research practice we discuss below involve fundamental issues of conceptualization and study design that cut across methods, but we also aim to highlight implications for quantitative research as a complement to existing best practice recommendations for research in this area that draw primarily from qualitative perspectives (e.g., Compton et al. 2018, Garrison 2022, Shuster 2021).

One set of improvements is already underway but remains incomplete: incorporating nonbinary gender measures in our nation's surveys and administrative data collection. The biggest challenge here is coordination: using comparable measures whenever possible to allow for synthesizing results across studies. Authoritative national population benchmarks are also needed to assist researchers with everything from designing appropriate sampling frames to applying survey weights (Kennedy et al. 2022). The Office of the Chief Statistician of the United States has issued best practice guidance recommending the two-step measure for federal statistical surveys (OCSOTUS 2023), but concerns about data privacy and respect for respondent autonomy remain paramount, and the two-step measure may not be appropriate in all contexts (NASEM 2022). For example, to produce the most inclusive counts, it relies on a question about sex assigned at birth that is unnecessary information in contexts such as the workplace or when applying for basic social services. Indeed, some scholars encourage rethinking the current ubiquity and seeming necessity of either sex or gender classification, with the alternative of degendering some administrative data systems instead (Shteyler et al. 2020, Wipfler 2016).

Much like with federal data collection on race and ethnicity (see OMB 2024), any guidance for gender measurement that emerges in the coming years will be only a minimum standard and cannot replace careful reflection by researchers about what additional information is needed for their specific research question or context. Also, like measurement guidance for race and ethnicity, which recently underwent its third major revision in the past half-century, recommendations for gender measurement will need to change with the times. The two-step approach has been shown to have very low item nonresponse, is generally well-understood by cisgender and transgender respondents of all ages, and has been successfully asked alongside other standard demographic questions in several prominent surveys (NASEM 2022). However, just as the term “transgender” arose in the 1990s and “nonbinary” and “genderqueer” gained prominence in the 2010s, new gender terminology may yet be on the horizon, necessitating adjustments to the available answer options. At minimum, research indicates that current young adult cohorts are much more likely to use nonbinary or gender expansive labels to identify themselves than their older counterparts (Brown 2022, Hammack et al. 2022). A new generation of Americans is also being raised with the possibility of nonbinary identity documents in many states, and with a broader range of gender-affirming and “gender-open” parenting practices (Meadow 2018, Rahilly 2022, Travers 2018), suggesting that what might seem like a small population at present—especially for statistical purposes—is likely to continue to grow in the coming years.

Of course, researchers should not only attend to populations when or because they are growing. Researchers should include transgender and nonbinary people in their scholarship because it is a more comprehensive and inclusive way to study the sex/gender system. For too long, essentialist ideology and binary typological thinking has limited research on sex and gender across both social science and medical disciplines (e.g., Albert & Delano 2022, Dubois & Shattuck-Heidorn 2021, Hyde et al. 2019, Lorber 1996, Suhomlinova et al. 2023). The calls for change have become

their own consensus: It is past time to revisit those assumptions—and the methods we employed that went along with them—that not only circumscribed the possibilities for human diversity but also occluded potentially more complex patterns of individual and group disparities. The idea that femininity and masculinity are mutually exclusive and opposite traits has been repeatedly debunked (Marcotte et al. 2023, Magliozzi et al. 2016). Female and male brains have yielded to “mosaics” (Joel 2021, p. 165). Even human bone density is known to be shaped by how we organize society according to gender (Fausto-Sterling 2005). These studies and more point not only to embracing more complex conceptualizations of sex and gender, and allowing for more categories, but also toward focusing our efforts to understand the processes and mechanisms behind the sex and gender inequality we observe. Knowing the complex relationships between sex and gender, and their many potential biological and social interactions (Springer et al. 2012), should only further encourage us to push research on gender inequality forward by accounting for that very complexity.

Advancing research on gender and gender inequality requires more than offering a third answer option to our demographic questions. All decisions about why sex or gender was included in research, as well as how the data were collected and the results were interpreted, should be carefully justified and explained (Heidari et al. 2016; see also Frohard-Dourlent et al. 2017). Social psychologists will need to not only include nonbinary respondents but also consider nonbinary primes and vignettes in their experiments (see Dray et al. 2020, Worthen 2021). Quantitative researchers will need to ask themselves when and why their results should be either measured or depicted categorically (Ritz & Greaves 2022), and all researchers will need to better account for response fluidity (Sumerau et al. 2020). Importantly, a change in a person’s gender identity can be accompanied by changes in other experiences, from their sexuality to how they are perceived racially by others (de Vries 2012, Diamond & Butterworth 2008). This underscores the need for both multidimensional and intersectional approaches that recognize not only the complexity to be unpacked within the concepts of sex and gender but also how experiences of inequality are rarely just gendered.

In addition to these obvious “dos”—incorporating nonbinary categories and respondents and reinvigorating our attention to both gradation and intersectional mechanisms—there are also important “don’ts,” or cautions for researchers going forward. For example, too often, research on transgender and nonbinary people focuses on negative outcomes, such as distress, discrimination, and health risks, at the expense of understanding positive experiences, including relief, euphoria, and joy (Barbee & Schrock 2019, Shuster & Westbrook 2022). It is also not uncommon for transgender and nonbinary people to be depicted as uniquely complicit in maintaining gender inequality and even exacerbating it (Vidal-Ortiz 2008) or perceived as valuable research subjects primarily for what they can teach cisgender people about the workings of the sex/gender system (Schilt & Lagos 2017; see also Monro et al. 2021). Qualitative as well as quantitative scholars need to be attentive to a range of ethical considerations to avoid causing harm, including, for example, through overburdening marginalized populations with research attention (Shuster 2021). Indeed, researchers have as much to learn about gender (non)conformity and the “undoing” or “redoing” of gender from cisgender people as we do from transgender and nonbinary people (see, e.g., Connell 2010, Hart et al. 2019, Kolber 2023, Sumerau & Holway 2022). None of these categories or experiences is more or less important to contemporary understanding of the sex/gender system: We all do gender and participate in systems of gender inequality, and we all have the capacity to resist, or conform to, such strictures, even as our power to do so in particular contexts may vary. Together, we must keep gender scholarship relevant in the present and look toward the future to understand how these processes might change the sex/gender system and resulting patterns of inequality.

DISCLOSURE STATEMENT

The authors are not aware of any affiliations, memberships, funding, or financial holdings that might be perceived as affecting the objectivity of this review.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

The authors are grateful to Shelley Correll, Apollo Rydzik, Robin Stryker, Sarah Thébaud, Laurel Westbrook, and members of the Stanford Sociology Workshop on Gender and Gender Inequality for comments and discussions.

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